

Tillie and the Wall

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The wall had been there ever since the mice could remember. They never paid attention to it. They never asked themselves what was on the other side, nor, for that matter, if there was another side at all. They went about their business as if the wall didn't exist.

The mice loved to talk. They chatted endlessly about this and that, but no one ever mentioned the wall. Only Tillie, the youngest, would stare at it, wondering about the other side.

At night, while the others were asleep, she would lie in her bed of straw, wide awake, imagining beyond the wall a beautiful, fantastic world inhabited by strange animals and plants.

"We must see the other side," she told her friends. "Let us try to climb." They tried, but as they climbed, the wall seemed higher and higher.

With a long, rusty nail they tried to make a hole to peep through. "It is only a question of patience!" said Tillie. But after working an entire morning they gave up, exhausted, without having made even a dent in the hard stone.

"The wall must end somewhere," Tillie said. They walked and walked for many hours. The wall apparently had no end.

But one day, not far from the wall, Tillie saw a worm digging itself into the black earth. How could she not have thought of that before? Why hadn't anyone thought of that before?

Full of excitement, Tillie began to dig. She dug and she dug ...

... until suddenly, almost blinded by the bright sunlight, she was on the other side of the wall! She couldn't believe her eyes: before her were mice, regular mice.

The mice gave Tillie a great welcome party. They took her to their celebration pebble (had she seen that before somewhere?). They made speeches in her honor and waved flags.

They then decided to go through Tillie's tunnel to see for themselves what the other side was like. One by one they followed Tillie.

And when the mice on Tillie's side of the wall saw what Tillie had discovered, there was another party. The mice threw confetti. Everyone shouted "TIL-LIE, TIL-LIE, TIL-LIE!" and they carried Tillie high in the air in triumph. Since that day the mice go freely from one side of the wall to the other, and they always remember that it was Tillie who first showed them the way.

- The opening spreads establish the long wall running through the meadow and Tillie, the youngest mouse, staring at it while the others chat and ignore it.

- The middle spreads show the failed attempts -- climbing the wall, the rusty nail, walking for the wall's end -- and the worm digging that gives Tillie the idea.
- The closing spreads show Tillie emerging into bright sunlight on the other side, the welcome party at the celebration pebble, the tunnel procession, and the confetti triumph.

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